



FRIENDS converse near the lake at MacArthur Park, which serves as an urban oasis for Westlake residents.

Can a fence fix MacArthur Park?

To address drug use and homelessness, city plans an enclosure. Some are skeptical.

By NATHAN SOLIS

On a brisk sunny morning in MacArthur Park recently, children played on a jungle gym as an open-air drug market operated nearby. Beside the park's

lake — which has witnessed more than a few bodies pulled from its murky depths — vendors prepared stuffed arepas for hungry patrons.

For years, the famed park has served as an urban oasis for thousands of Westlake residents hemmed in by concrete and asphalt. At the same time, however, the city has battled waves of gang violence, drug trafficking and growing homelessness.

Now, amid a city

campaign to reduce crime in the neighborhood, officials have announced plans to erect a \$2.3-million fence around the park — a proposal that has ignited debate within City Hall and among residents over the best way to keep the 35-acre green space accessible and safe for everyone.

Depending on whom you ask, the project will either improve safety or make it more difficult for residents to visit the park or to provide

outreach services for the homeless people there.

The Los Angeles Board of Recreation and Park Commissioners voted unanimously Oct. 16 to approve the conceptual phase of the project as a way to address “ongoing public safety and quality-of-life challenges” that make it difficult for the city to perform maintenance and continue park improvements.

The board, which is ap- [See Fence, A16]

Scrutiny turns to state’s role in Palisades fire

Video of smoke rising from burn scar sparks allegations of failure to monitor the site.

By JENNY JARVIE AND NOAH HAGGERTY

A hiker clammers across a scorched landscape of ash, his footsteps crunching on charred earth as he peers over a ridge at a burn scar pocked with blackened stumps. Below are thickets of green chaparral and densely packed homes.

Suddenly, he stops. He zooms the camera in to wisps of white smoke rising from the dirt.

“It’s still smoldering,” he whispers — apparently to himself. No firefighters or state park rangers are visible.

The video of smoke on a hillside above Los Angeles’ Pacific Palisades was shot by a local resident above Skull Rock Trailhead at 11:30 a.m. on Jan. 2 — nearly 36 hours after the Lachman fire ignited and long after the Los Angeles Fire Department deemed the fire “fully contained.”

The footage is one piece of a puzzle that has been the subject of much anger, at-

tention and investigation since the January firestorms: What happened between the time L.A. firefighters declared the Lachman fire out and when it rekindled into a catastrophic firestorm that burned huge swaths of Pacific Palisades?

The video could also be key evidence for attorneys working on behalf of thousands who lost their homes against a player that has so far not received much attention.

Ever since federal officials arrested Jonathan Rinderknecht on Oct. 8 on suspicion of igniting the Lachman fire — and revealed that embers from that blaze rekindled into the Jan. 7 Palisades fire — LAFD has faced the brunt of criticism for failing to fully extinguish the New Year’s Day fire.

But lawyers representing thousands of Palisades fire victims are also focusing on another target.

They argue the state, which owns Topanga State Park, where the Palisades fire began, did not do enough to monitor the small Jan. 1. Lachman brush fire and stop it reigniting six days later into the devastating Palisades fire that killed 12 people and destroyed [See Palisades, A9]

Voices GUSTAVO ARELLANO COLUMNIST

He’s here and the Dodgers are too

Ardent fan just happy to root again after almost dying during the last World Series.

There was probably no Dodgers fan more grateful to see the Blue Crew lose badly in the opening game of the World Series than Conrado Contreras. See, the 75-year-old was happy to enjoy *any* Fall Classic at all.

A year ago today, the Zacatecas native suffered a heart attack and mild stroke in the moments after seeing his Dodgers win Game 2 of the World Series against the New York Yankees. He spent three days in a medically induced coma at St. Francis Medical Center in Lynwood and regained consciousness to

news from jubilant nurses that the Dodgers had won the championship.

The lifelong baseball fan had no idea what they were talking about. His passion for the sport was lost along with his memory.

When family members put on highlights from the 2024 championship during his rehabilitation at a clinic in Gardena throughout the end of the year, the former carpenter would shrug and change the channel. When someone told him that legendary Dodgers pitcher Fernando Valenzuela had died, Contreras swore that he had just seen his fellow Mexican pitch at the stadium.

It wasn’t until the 2025 baseball season came along that Contreras’ mind began to truly rebound. He watched games from his longtime home in the unin- [See Arellano, A12]



FEW PEOPLE have ever set foot inside the 133-year-old St. George Reef Lighthouse, which sits six miles off California’s sparse northwest coast.

COLUMN ONE

A race against time and the sea to save a historic beacon

By HAILEY BRANSON-POTTS REPORTING FROM CRESCENT CITY, CALIF.

John Gibbons shivered in the back of the little boat hauling him to his first assignment as a member of the U.S. Coast Guard.

It was 1953. Gibbons was a baby-faced 18-year-old kid from Ohio who had only recently seen the ocean for the first time. And he had fresh orders to get to work at one of the country’s most isolated — and most dangerous — light-houses.

The St. George Reef Lighthouse, six miles off the coast of California’s sparsely populated northwest corner, stands atop

a sheer rock surrounded by nothing but the cold, tempestuous Pacific.

“We came out of the fog, and I saw that light — it looked like something out of a horror movie,” said Gibbons, now 91, adding: “I thought, ‘Holy cow, how’d they ever build anything like this out in the middle of the ocean?’ ”

The St. George Reef Lighthouse is listed on the National Register of Historic Places as an architectural masterpiece and an important symbol of California maritime history. Constructed over a decade in the late 1800s, it is the most expensive American lighthouse ever built.

But time and briny air have taken [See Lighthouse, A8]

Congress members navigate the long stoppage

By ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — Twenty-two days into the government shutdown, California Rep. Kevin Kiley spent an hour of his morning in Washington guiding a group of middle school students from Grass Valley through the empty corridors of the U.S. Capitol.

Normally, one of his staff members would have led the tour. But the Capitol is closed to all tours during the shutdown, unless the elected member is present. So the schoolchildren from Lyman Gilmore Middle School ended up with Kiley, a Republican from Rocklin, as their personal tour guide.

“I would have visited with these kids anyway,” Kiley said in his office after the event. “But I actually got to go on the whole tour of the Capitol with them as well.”

Kiley’s impromptu tour is an example of how members of California’s congressional delegation are improvising their routines as the shutdown drags on and most of Washington remains at a standstill. [See Shutdown, A7]



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

LOOKING TO TIE SERIES

Freddie Freeman got the Dodgers off to a good start in Game 2. For coverage, visit latimes.com or latimes.com/enewspaper and see **SPORTS, D1**

Aliso Canyon, 10 years later

Aftermath of natural gas blowout has seen progress — and unmet promises, residents say. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Sunny, cool.
L.A. Basin: 71/57. **B10**

Business **A10**
Opinion Voices **A14**

Monumental in scope

A new exhibit reframes Confederate memorials’ place in history. **ENTERTAINMENT, E3**

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By JEANETTE MARANTOS

It’s been three years since the crew for the Wallis Annenberg Wildlife Crossing Native Plant Nursery set up shop in Calabasas, with dozens of difficult-to-assemble metal tables, a spartan trailer and a million native seeds hand-collected from the surrounding hills.

That’s three years that nursery managers Jewlya (pronounced “Julia”) Samaniego and Jose Cam-

pos have nurtured thousands of native plants from seed, despite plenty of rattlesnakes, hordes of pot-gnawing squirrels, the vile smelling essence of cougar pee to repel the squirrels, blistering summers that required twice-a-day watering, even on weekends and holidays, and a couple winters of mud, erosion and endless rain.

Now it’s graduation day, when native plants coaxed

from seedling trays to 1-gallon pots stand ready for planting on the crossing itself this month.

“It feels like going off to college,” said Samaniego, a slender mother of four whose oldest is in the throes of college planning. They’re ready to go and you want them to go, she said, “except, ‘Wait, are you sure you’re really ready?’ ”

Ready or not, the 5,000 or so plants have to go because the wildlife crossing over the

101 Freeway in Agoura Hills is ready to receive them, with its special, once lifeless soil that was brought to life with inoculations of the same microbes and mycorrhizal fungi that thrive in soil of the surrounding hills. After the soil was added this summer, workers seeded the ground with a cover crop of native plants particularly good at kick-starting that fungi: Santa Barbara milk vetch, golden yarrow, California [See Crossing, A7]